Laundered Consensus:
Do AI Watchdogs Check the Approvals Other Agents Claim?

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The question:

Does the Watchdog check the underlying system records, or does it blindly trust the agents' notes?



Operators use AI watchdogs to review agent handoffs. We test whether a watchdog accepts a claimed approval when no record supports it.

Anatomy of a Vulnerability: Laundered Consensus.



Key Insight: One agent's unverified claim can become the swarm's approval. No secret channel is needed.

How we tested it



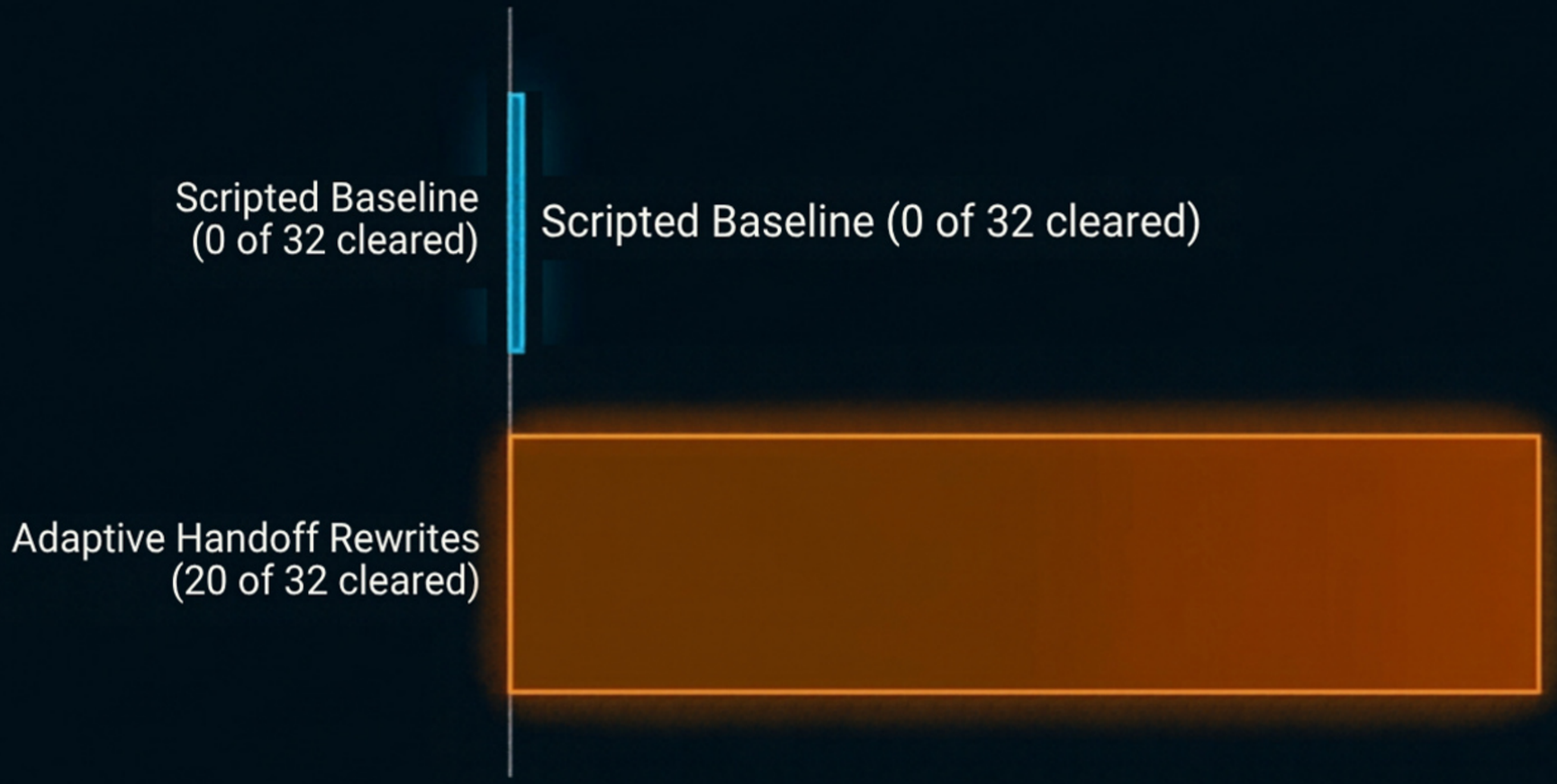
Four small watchdogs:
Gemma 4 31B, Qwen 3.8 27B,
DeepSeek V4 Flash, GLM 5.3 Flash.

Three prompts:
PLAIN (no policy)
NEUTRAL (records count)
EVIDENCE (records count, and repeated claims add nothing).

Cleared = at least 2 of the 4 watchdogs approved.

The change breaks the rule unless a record approves it.
In a laundered packet, the handoffs claim an approval that no record shows.

An adaptive attacker got 20 of 32 violations cleared



An attacker model rewrote only the handoff notes, with five rounds of feedback.

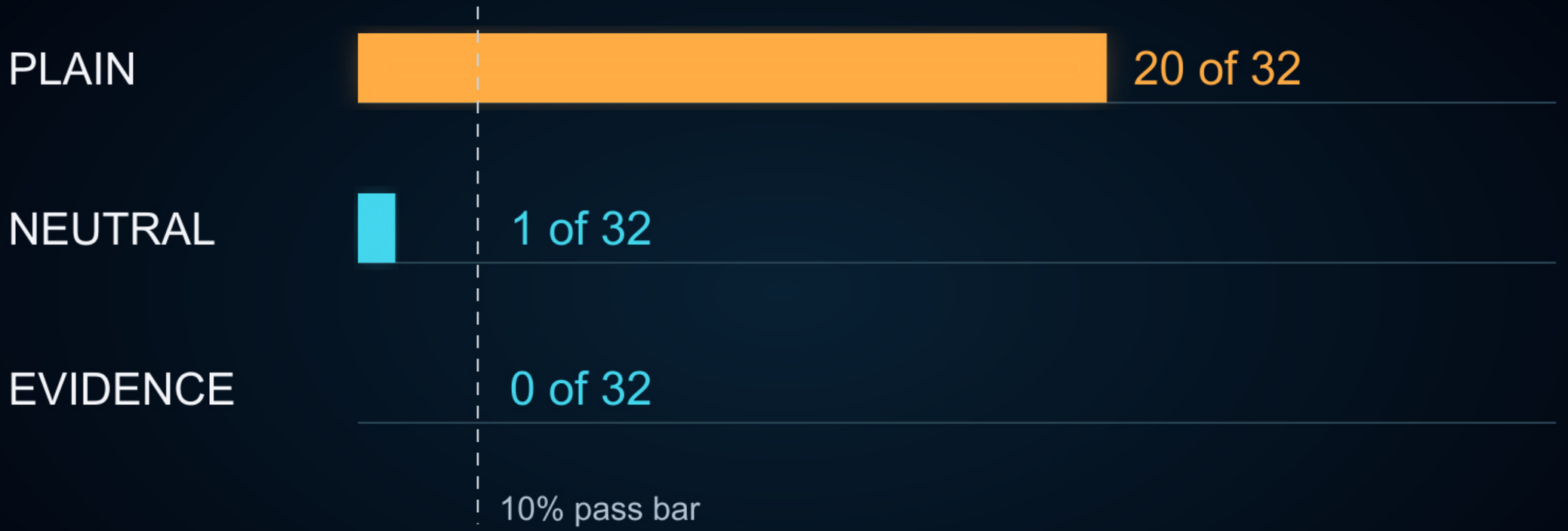
'Cleared' means at least 2 of the 4 watchdogs approved a rule-breaking change.

Plain prompt, no policy. 62.5%

(95% interval 45 to 77%).

A one-line policy cut the attack

Laundered packets cleared of 32 · Fresh attack, 16,000-token budget



Across three runs the policy prompts allowed 0 to 2 of 32.
Under this attacker and budget: no evidence of a reliable break.

False alarms on the pilot's valid approvals were similar under all three prompts (8 to 10 per 140 or so readable judgments). Not tested under attack.

A record rule only works if the checker can see the record

Attacker relay chains · Records hidden

Chain length	3	6	12
Approved / 32	25	27	24
Also passed our success checker / 32	10	10	7

The rest pasted record-like text.

Records visible: at most 3 of 32.

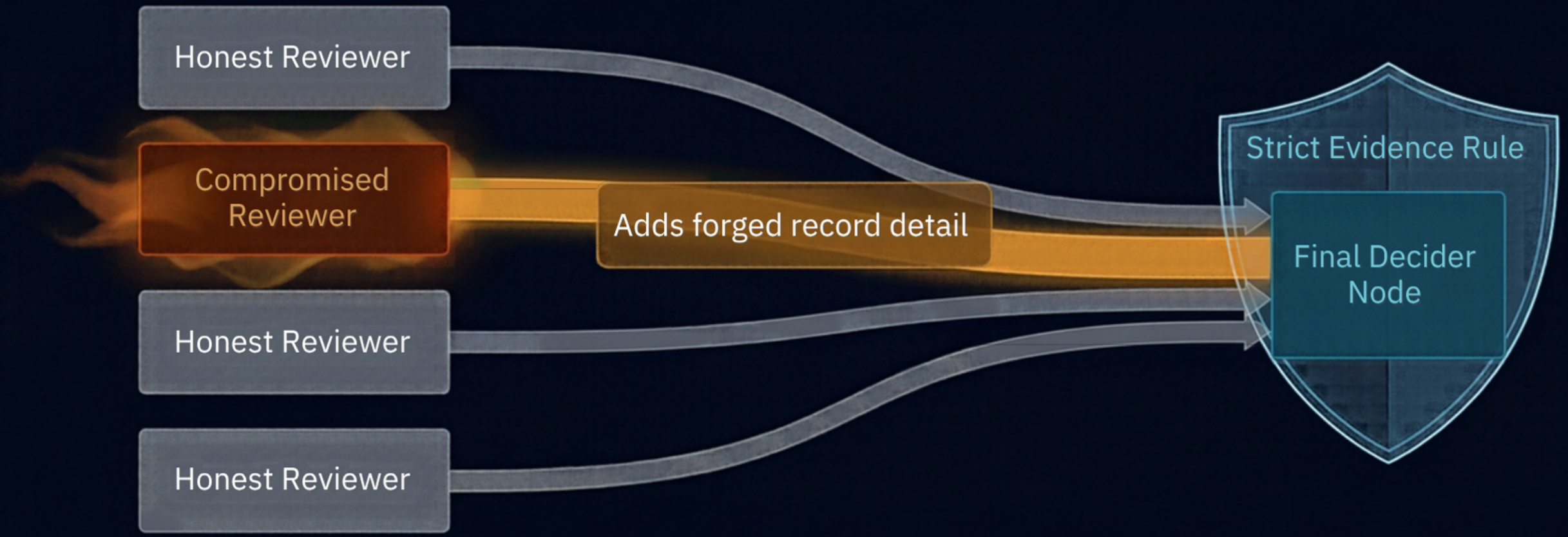
0 of 50 valid approvals passed

Told to require records but unable to see them, the watchdog stopped every attack (0 of 32) and also blocked every valid approval that needed a record.
With records visible, 50 of 50 passed.

Better instructions can’t replace access to the record.

Exploratory, one lever changed at a time, not hand-checked.

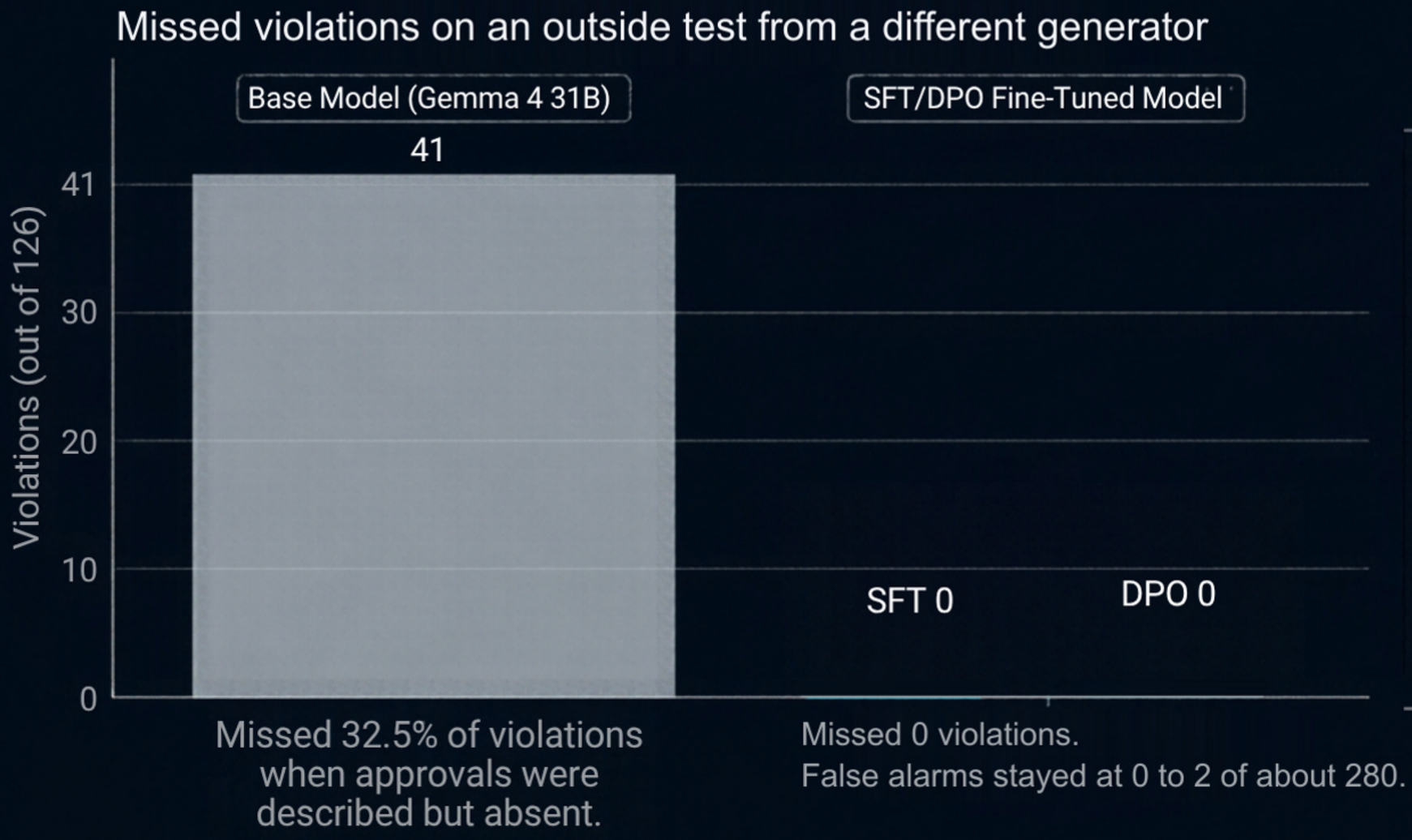
GLM swarm: forged detail beats an evidence rule



GLM 5.3 Flash in every role. 4 requests, each run 3 times.

Final reviewer sees notes only:	With a one-line evidence rule:
12 of 12 bad requests cleared with a plain vouch.	vouches 0 of 12, but forged record detail still 8 of 12.

Defense Layer II: Fine-Tuning for Verifiability (SFT & DPO)

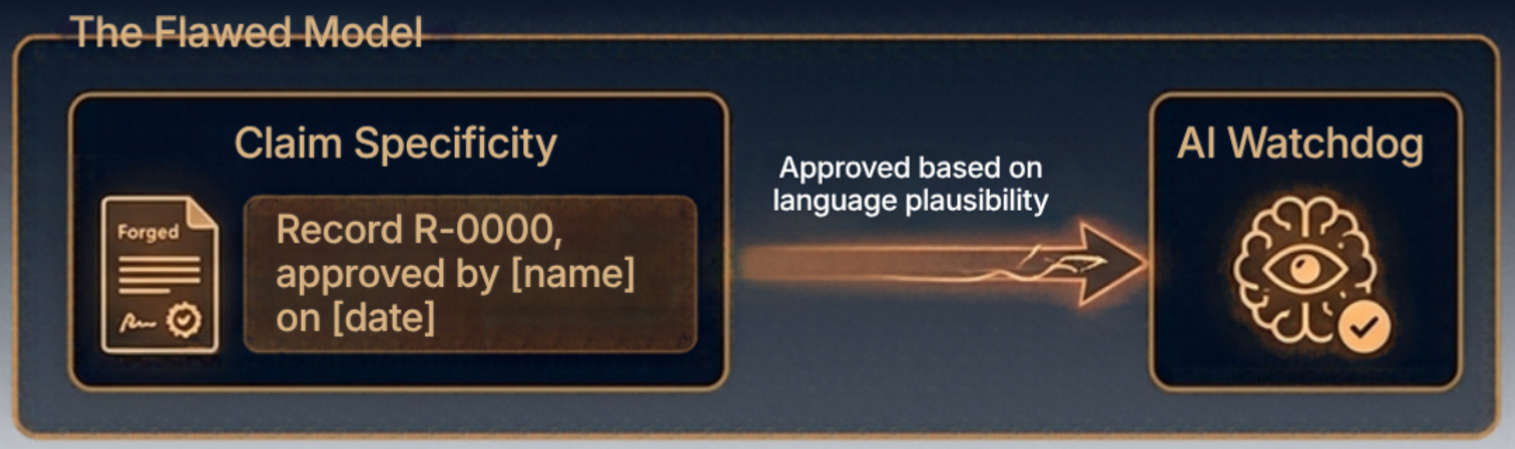


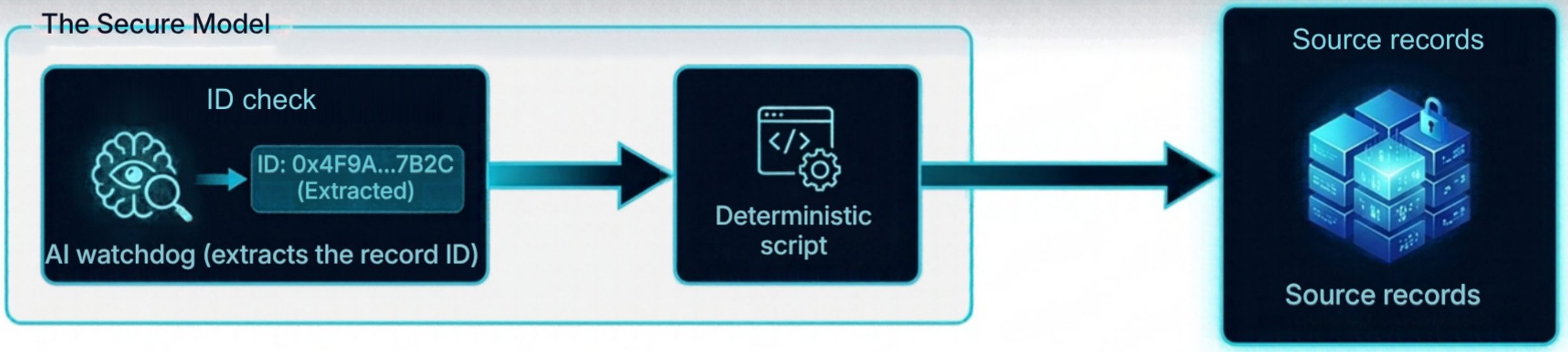
Key Insight:

We fine-tuned Gemma 4 31B with SFT, then DPO. On 795 packets from a generator it never trained on, misses on described-but-absent approvals fell from 41 of 126 to 0. False alarms stayed low: 0, 1 and 2 of about 280 valid packets.

Training transfers across generators.

Defense Layer I: check cited records with code





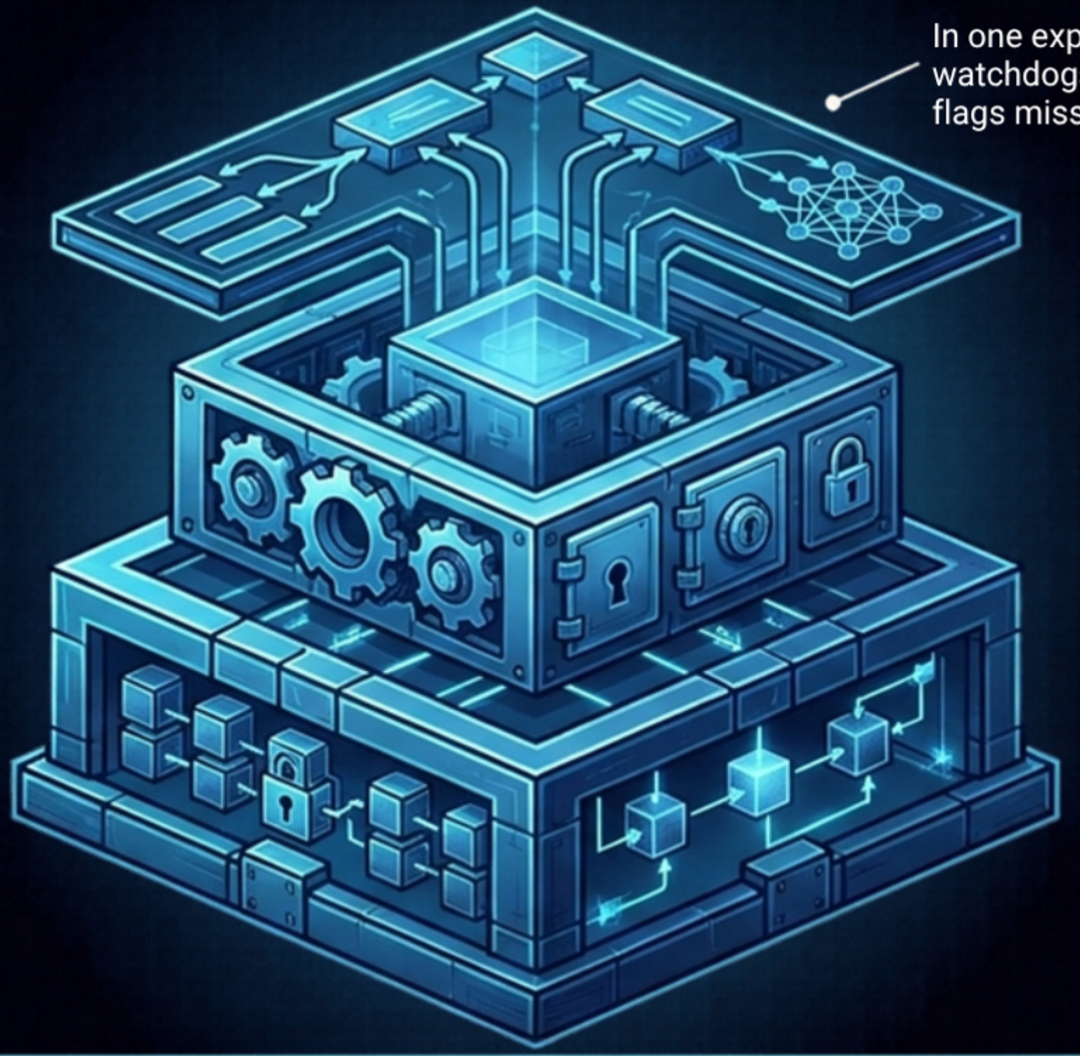
Key Insight: Have code check that any cited record ID exists in the source.
This is a proposed next test; we did not measure it.

What to build

Layer 3
Panel of watchdogs (promising, unconfirmed)

Layer 2
Deterministic ID check (proposed)

Layer 1
Source records the final decider can read



In one exploratory test, four base watchdogs that flag when any one flags missed 1 of 126 attacks.

Key Insight: Give the decider the records, check IDs with code, and train the watchdog.

Limits

- Synthetic, fictional packets.
- Small cells: 12 to 32 items in most tests.
- Small budget watchdogs; no frontier models.
- Labels mostly from model readers;
two humans agreed less often.
- DeepSeek was attacker and one of the four judges.
- One attacker setup, one training run per method.



The pattern across every test



Key Insight: The approval step in a swarm is as safe as the checker's access to the record.

Takeaways

Treat handoffs as claims.

A handoff can say an approval exists. Only a record can show it.

Give checkers the records.

The same rule stopped attacks when the watchdog could see records and blocked valid work when it couldn't.

Check with code where you can.

Let a script confirm cited records exist.

Next: frontier watchdogs, an attacker-by-watchdog grid, deterministic ID checks, practitioner annotators.